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Calif. Legislature passes two resolutions

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Both houses of the California Legislature voted last week to pass two separate resolutions condemning President Donald Trump's social media post depicting the Obamas as apes.

Authored by members of the California Legislative Black Caucus (CLBC), the resolutions passed respectively in the California State Assembly and Senate on Feb. 9.

Assembly House Resolution (HR 84), introduced by Assemblymember Isaac Bryan (D-Ladera Heights), vice chair of CLBC, passed with unanimous support, 62-0. Senate Resolution (SR) 77, presented by the chair of the CLBC, Sen. Akilah Weber Pierson (D-San Diego), was also approved with a 28-0 vote.

"Today, I rise on behalf of the Black Legislative Caucus to condemn the racist and dehumanizing video displayed by President Donald Trump against President Barack Obama and Mrs. Michelle Obama," Weber Pierson said on the Senate floor.

"This imagery has no place in our country, no place in our democracy, and absolutely no place coming from the President of the United States," she continued.

Lawmakers in both chambers stressed that the post came during the centennial observance of Black History Month — a time intended to celebrate the achievements and enduring contributions of Black Americans, not to circulate imagery that demeans or dehumanizes them.

Senators Lola Smallwood-Cuevas (D-Los Angeles) and Laura Richardson (D-Inglewood), both members of the CLBC co-authored the resolution, which calls for an official and unequivocal apology to the Obamas.

HR 84 was co-introduced by a long list of CLBC coauthors, including Assemblymembers Mia Bonta (D-Alameda), Sade Elhawary (D-Los Angeles), Mike Gipson (D-Carson), Corey Jackson (D-Moreno Valley), Tina McKinnor (D-Inglewood), Rhodesia Ransom (D-Stockton), LaShae Sharp-Collins (D-La Mesa), and Wilson (D-Suisun City).

"To the Black children who saw Trump refer to the Obamas as apes, know that you are not bound by the bigoted imagination of a racist. You are beautiful and boundless," Bryan posted on his Instagram account.

Of the 15 Assembly Republicans present, nine voted in favor of HR 84, while six declined to vote. Republican Minority leader Heath Flora (Ripon); Leticia Castillo (Corona); Laurie Davies (Laguna Nigel); Jeff Gonzalez (Indio); Josh Hoover (Folsom); Natasha Johnson (Lake Elsinore); Tri Ta (Westminster); Juan Alanis (Modesto);and Greg Wallis (Rancho Mirage) voted in favor of HR 84.

Assemblymember David Tangipa (R-Clovis) told his colleagues that Trump was wrong for the posting and "the President knows he was wrong." After saying his statement on the subject, Assemblymember McKinnor hugged Tangipa before he exited the floor.

Tangipa was one of the six Republicans in the Assembly who abstained from voting, but he said he wanted to "make sure my words go on record in this building."

"I know that it was wrong, and I stand in solidarity with you because you deserve that respect," Tangipa said to his colleagues across the aisle. "We understand right now that we need people to work together in this time, or we're at each other's throats."

In the upper house, two Republicans voted in favor of the resolution. Sens. Roger Niello (R-Roseville) and Sen. Marie Alvarado-Gil (R-Jackson).

Senate President pro Tempore Monique Limón (D-Santa Barbara) supported and presided over the passage of SR 77.

She said the video continues "centuries of racist pain." Senate Minority Leader Brian Jones (R-Santee) sided with Limón, saying the post was "offensive and unacceptable," but he abstained from voting.

While the White House initially defended the clip as a "meme" before deleting it 12 hours later, Trump later stated he would not apologize because he "didn't make a mistake." The posting was attributed to a staffer who has yet to be identified.

During a news conference at the CalVet on Feb. 8, Gov. Newsom told California Black Media (CBM) that a universal condemnation of the posting by the public is warranted, regardless of anyone's political leanings.

"It's disgraceful. It's racist. It's abhorrent," Newsom said. "The President of the United States sending out a racist trope should disgust every human being in this room. Everyone. I don't care if you watched Kid Rock this [Super Bowl] weekend or Bad Bunny."

"In any other circumstance, that person would be fired, the board of directors would ask for him to be fired, he would be shamed and humiliated, and he would have apologized. He did none of the above," Newsom said, arguing that the public discourse moved on too quickly from the uproar.

HR 84 garnered the support of several legislative caucuses, including the LGBTQ, Latino, Asian American Pacific Islander (AAPI), Jewish, Native American, and Women's.

Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino); James Ramos (D-Highland); Chris Ward (D-San Diego); and Pilar Schiavo (D-Chatsworth) were among the speakers. Assemblymember Liz Ortega (D-San Leandro), the Vice Chair of the Legislative Latino Caucus, spoke in support, noting that the post was consistent with a "long pattern of racist remarks."

Ramos stated that it was time for those with a "moral compass" to stand united against "blatant racism" and division. The first California Native American elected to the state legislature emphasized that Trump's actions represent history repeating itself.

Ramos added that the state has worked diligently to "acknowledge the past" and "right the wrongs," but the posting of the video undermines those efforts.

Gonzalez supported and voted in favor of HR 84. He also quoted religious passages in the spirit of civil rights icon Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., as he lauded the progressive dynamics of California politics.

"We stand in the chamber that represents the diverse tapestry of the Golden State. A state that has always been a laboratory for the American experiment," Gonzalez said. "Racism is a ghost that haunts our history, but it does not have to be the architect of our future."

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